

DARPA-SN-25-08

Special Notice

Industry Day Special Notice:

Pulling Guard

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Posted: February 21, 2025



Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency

Tactical Technology Office (TTO)

675 North Randolph Street

Arlington, VA 22203-2114

**Industry Day
Special Notice DARPA-SN-25-08**

**Pulling Guard
Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency (DARPA)
Tactical Technology Office (TTO)**

POSTING DATE: February 21, 2025

SPECIAL NOTICE (SN): DARPA-SN-25-08: Pulling Guard Industry Day

DATE: March 18, 2025

LOCATION: Amentum Services Conference Center, 4121 Wilson Blvd, Suite 200,
Arlington VA 22203

CLASSIFICATION LEVEL: Controlled Unclassified Information (CUI) and SECRET level

REGISTRATION CLOSURES: March 11, 2025, at 4:00 p.m. Eastern Time (ET)

REGISTRATION WEBSITE: <https://creative.spa.com/darpa/tto/pullingguard/id/>

E-MAIL: DARPA-SN-25-08@darpa.mil

TECHNICAL POC: Dr. Christopher Kent, TTO Program Manager

PULLING GUARD INDUSTRY DAY:

The Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency (DARPA) Tactical Technology Office (TTO) is sponsoring an Industry Day to provide information to potential proposers on the objectives of the Pulling Guard program in advance of a planned Broad Agency Announcement (BAA). The Industry Day will be held on **March 18, 2025**, at the Amentum Services Conference Center, 4121 Wilson Blvd, Suite 200, Arlington, VA 22203 from **9:00 a.m. to 4:00 p.m. ET. Check-in begins at 8:15 a.m. ET.** Advance registration is required to attend any portion of Industry Day.

The Industry Day will include overview presentations by government personnel as well as information sessions to respond to questions from participants.

Potential proposers can request a Program Overview brief via DARPA-SN-25-08@darpa.mil to address the scope and shape attendance. Requestors must verify they comply with regulations applicable to receiving and storing CUI material in accordance with DoD Instruction 5200.48 CONTROLLED UNCLASSIFIED INFORMATION (CUI) and National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST) Special Publication 800-171 Protecting CUI in Nonfederal Systems and Organizations prior to submitting the request. The Government team will send this brief by DoD Secure Access File Exchange (SAFE) or encrypted email and include further details for document pick-up in a reply email.

PROGRAM OBJECTIVE AND DESCRIPTION:

The objective of the Pulling Guard program is the development and demonstration of a semi-autonomous platform that enhances survivability of unarmed logistics vessels from

potential threats, primarily uncrewed surface vehicles (USVs). Although solutions shall retain a remote supervisor in the loop who retains authority for engagement decisions, the Pulling Guard system requires sufficient autonomy to allow for supervision of multiple systems over a secure connection.

The focus of the Pulling Guard program is the integration and marinization of existing sensors and effectors on a vehicle with an emphasis on modularity in both software and hardware. The program focus on modularity is based on the desire for an ongoing, rapid development cycle that evolves as new threats emerge and expands the total addressable market with tailored variants that address the statutory or regulatory compliance items necessary for export variants.

The Pulling Guard program is notionally planned for two (2) phases, with the initial BAA covering the Development Phase (18 months). A second BAA will cover a second phase with a reduced number of performers (from the first phase) focused on Integration, Manufacturing, and Commercial Transition (21 months).

The Development Phase may include two focus areas (FA) with multiple performers for (FA1) platform development and multiple performers for (FA2) sensor/kill chain development. This program structure may require cross-performer engagement on the development and agreement on interfaces (physical and digital) and an iterative design cycle approach to mature systems from concept to delivery.

The Pulling Guard program has a dedicated focus on resilient software that starts secure and builds capability. DARPA's preferred method to achieve this goal is the use of formal methods, which is an umbrella term for a range of mathematically rigorous techniques for producing software and machine-checkable evidence of software performance. For more information on Formal Method, please refer to the Best Practices Guide posted on to SAM.gov¹.

Integration, Manufacture, and Commercial Transition (Phase 2) may include a mix of Phase 1 performers with focus on final design, manufacture of initial variants, demonstration events, and execution of commercial strategy.

¹ <https://sam.gov/opp/1fbef90fc098420e9e942f9ce2b643f5/view>

REGISTRATION INFORMATION:

Participants must register for the Industry Day through the registration website:

<https://creative.spa.com/darpa/tto/pullingguard/id/>

The Industry Day will consist of a morning session conducted at the Controlled Unclassified Information (CUI) level, an afternoon session conducted at the SECRET level, and question and answer (Q&A) periods for both. The Industry Day agenda is as follows:

3/18/2025 (Morning Session)			
Time ET	Event	Location	Classification
8:15 a.m. - 9:00 a.m.	Check-In	Amentum Conference Center / MS Teams N/A	UNCLASS
9:00 a.m. - 11:30 a.m.	Industry Day		CUI
11:30 a.m. - 12:30 p.m.	UNCLASS Q&A Session		UNCLASS / Up to CUI
12:30 p.m. - 1:30 p.m.	Lunch Break / On Own		N/A
3/18/2025 (Afternoon Session)			
Time ET	Event	Location	Classification
1:30 p.m. - 2:00 p.m.	Classified Program Overview	Amentum Conference Center	Collateral SECRET
2:00 p.m. - 2:45 p.m.	Classified Q&A Session		
2:45 p.m. - 2:55 p.m.	Classified Closing Remarks		
2:55 p.m. - 4:00 p.m.	Networking Opportunity		
3/19/2025 (Morning Session Only)			
Time ET	Event	Location	Classification
9:00 a.m. - 12:00 p.m.	One on One Meetings	DARPA / MS Teams	Collateral SECRET/CUI
To attend the morning session only, please select the In-Person Morning or Virtual Morning option when registering.			
To attend both the morning and afternoon sessions, please select the In-Person All Day option when registering.			

Performers wishing to attend the afternoon session may do so only in person and only with an active SECRET clearance.

Performers have the option to attend the morning session virtually over Microsoft Teams as well as in person at the Amentum Services Conference Center. The Government Program Team will provide the event link and further directions on virtual event access once registration closes. All attendees accessing CUI agree to protect CUI in accordance with DoD Instruction 5200.48 CONTROLLED UNCLASSIFIED INFORMATION (CUI) and NIST Special Publication 800-171 Protecting Controlled Unclassified

Information in Nonfederal Systems and Organizations. Virtual attendees must complete the required DARPA Form 104 "DARPA Conference Center Visitor Requirements for Unclassified Meetings," for all unclassified events and submit the form to the DARPA Security and Intelligence Directorate (SID) via the eForm on the registration website. Once identity and eligibility determinations are complete, the government team will provide a meeting link to vetted participants via the official (e.g., company, organization, university, etc.) email provided on the DARPA Form 104. Participants must join the meeting via an internet browser or the Microsoft Teams application and may not dial in via a telephone number. Forwarding of the meeting link is prohibited, and participants may not use a personal account (e.g., an email domain available to the general public) to obtain the link. Virtual attendees will be required to present Government issued photo identification to enter the virtual event.

Due to space limitations of the conference facility, in-person attendance is limited to the first 125 registrants with a SECRET clearance, on a first-come first-served basis with no more than three (3) representatives per organization. Virtual attendance to the CUI morning session is limited to no more than three (3) representatives per organization. An organization includes all business units, divisions, etc. within a single company. Attendees are encouraged to coordinate attendance internally within their organizations prior to registration. Additional attendees for each company may be placed on the waitlist and notified if a seat becomes available after registration closes.

PLEASE NOTE THE REGISTRATION CLOSING DATE AND TIME ON PAGE 1. Visit requests, security clearances, and other applicable documents should also be sent in by this time.

The afternoon Industry Day session will be conducted at the SECRET level. Security clearances and other applicable documents should be sent to the Amentum Conference Center by March 11, 2025.

Upon entry to in-person events, all attendees will be required to present Government-issued photo identification that is compliant with the REAL ID Act of 2005, and an acceptable proof of U.S. citizenship or permanent resident status (Green Card holders). Examples may include:

- State-issued driver's license, or,
- U.S. passport, or,
- U.S. Permanent Resident card, or,
- Copy of birth certificate.

NOTE: Before individuals transmit Personally Identifiable Information (PII) or other sensitive data to DARPA, it is recommended that they apply appropriate physical, administrative, and technical protocols to safeguard their privacy. DARPA will secure all received PII and sensitive personal data in a controlled environment and protect it from unauthorized access, use, or disclosure.

SECURITY INFORMATION:

Attendance is limited to individuals who are U.S. Citizens or U.S. Permanent Residents (Green Card holders), representing U.S. companies only. Green Card holders are required to submit a U.S. Permanent Resident and Foreign National Visit Request (DARPA Form 60 <https://dtsn.darpa.mil/eform60>). Failure to complete and submit all required forms by the close of registration may result in the cancellation of registration requests.

For collateral-level visits to the Amentum Conference Center, please fax your clearance/visit request to Amentum Services at (571) 428-4358 or send it via DISS SMO Code: 1EL81. The Technical POC is Dr. Christopher Kent, and the Amentum Security POC is Johnnie Rapier. The purpose is to attend the Pulling Guard Industry Day DARPA-SN-25-08. For clearance receipt/verification, please email johnnie.rapier@amentum.com or call (571) 428-4328. Clearances must be received by the registration closing date listed on page 1. Any clearances sent to DARPA will not be forwarded to the Amentum Conference Center.

No cell phones, electronic devices, recording, or photography will be permitted during Industry Day events at the Conference Center. Storage is available for small electronics.

ONE-ON-ONE OPPORTUNITIES

There will be limited opportunities to meet individually (either virtually or in person at DARPA HQ) with the Program Manager, Dr. Christopher Kent, for 15 minutes on the morning of March 19, 2025. Please email DARPA-SN-25-08@darpa.mil by March 11, 2025, to request an individual session.

The Government team will conduct in-person one-on-one sessions at DARPA HQ, 675 N Randolph Street, Arlington, VA 22203. For collateral-level visits to DARPA, please send your clearance/visit request to DARPA by fax at (703) 528-3655, by sending an encrypted email to VWC@DARPA.mil, or via DISS using SMO Code: DDAAUS4.

TEAMING OPPORTUNITES

DARPA hosts Industry Days to promote teaming arrangements between researchers; provide potential performers with information on whether and how they might respond to the Government's research and development solicitations; and to increase efficiency in proposal preparation and evaluation. Therefore, Industry Days are open only to registered potential proposers. To maximize the pool of innovative proposal concepts, DARPA strongly encourages participation in these events and subsequent solicitations by non-traditional performers, including small businesses, academic and research institutions, and first-time Government contractors.

A list of registrants' contact information will be made available to attendees following the Industry Day to facilitate interchange among interested proposers. **If you would**

NOT like your contact information included on this list, please notify us when registering.

During the Industry Day, each organization (not each attendee) will have the opportunity to introduce itself as part of an around-the-room introduction (thirty seconds or less per organization).

Attendance at the Pulling Guard Industry Day is voluntary and is not required to propose to a subsequent BAA (if any) on this topic. The Industry Day does not constitute a formal solicitation for proposals or abstracts. This announcement is issued solely for information and program planning purposes and is not a Request for Information (RFI). Since this is not an RFI, no submissions against this notice will be accepted by the Government. DARPA will not provide reimbursement for costs incurred to participate in this Industry Day.